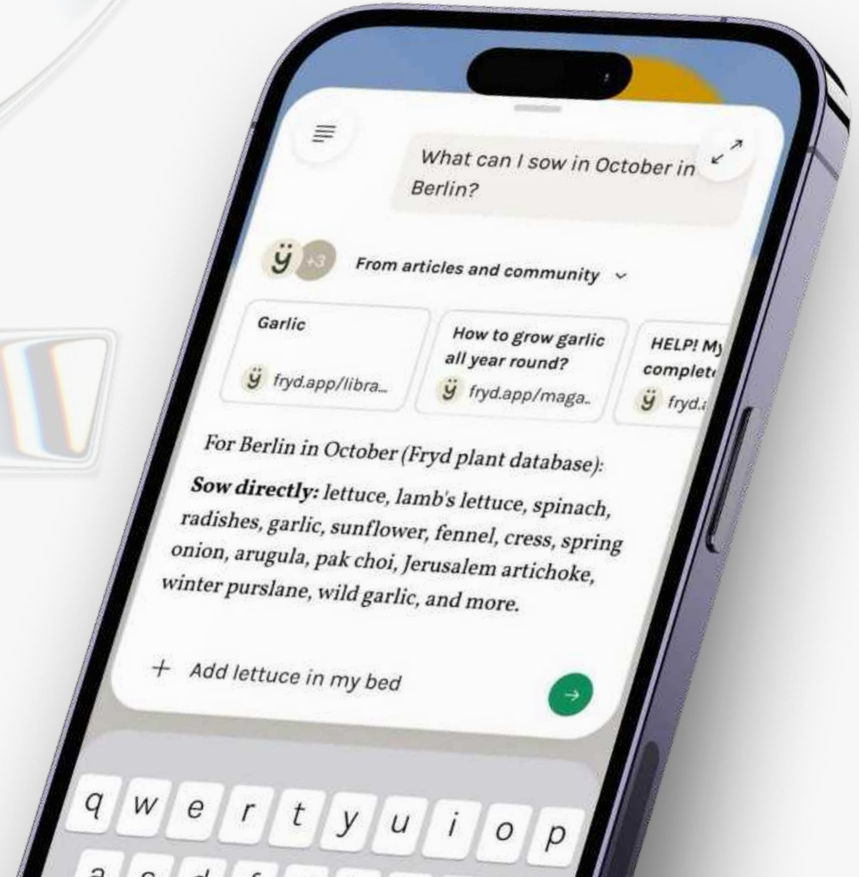
Moving from planning tool to confidence tool: Fryd as an AI conversation app



Try this

I have a raised bed, 2 by 1 metres

What can I still sow now?

Why are my tomato leaves yellow?

Year

2026

Role

UX research

UX/UI Design

Experimentation Strategy

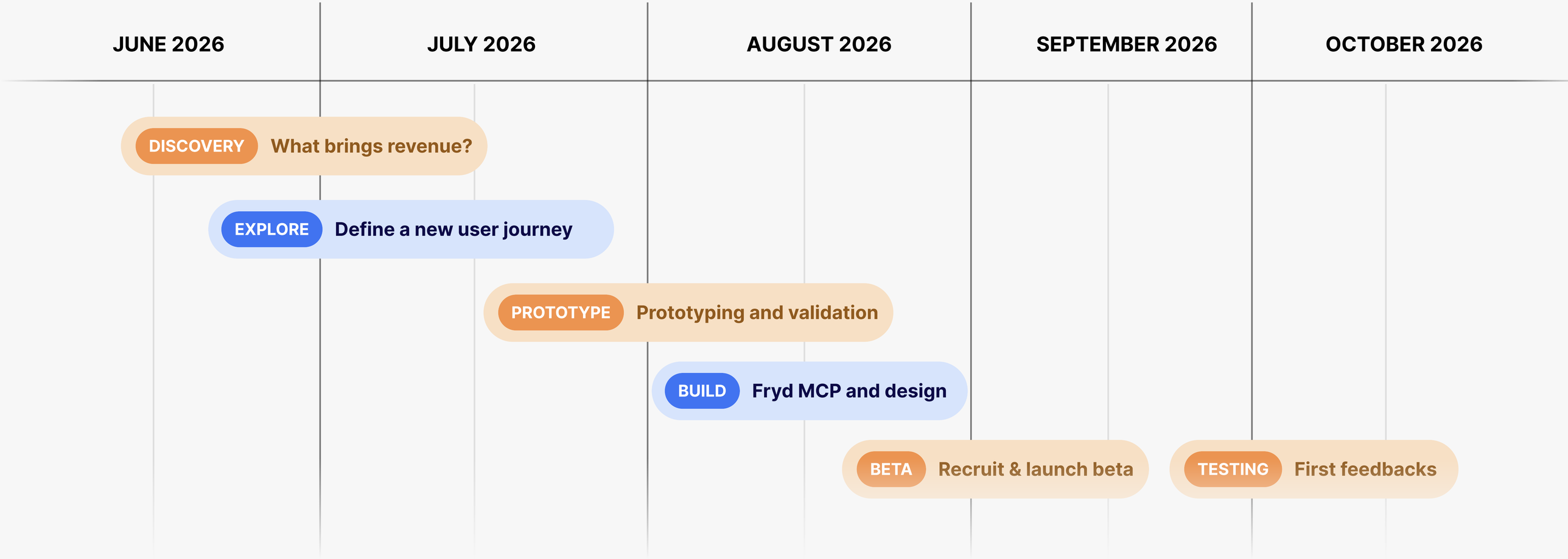
Context

What if we went even further in simplifying Fryd, and automated every time-consuming, feature-heavy action? What if conversation replaced navigation?

That's **Simple Fryd**: an AI conversational Fryd, built on 4 core actions and 1 MCP that ties together all the gardening knowledge we've built over the years. I designed it, and it's now in beta with 50+ users and growing.

Challenge

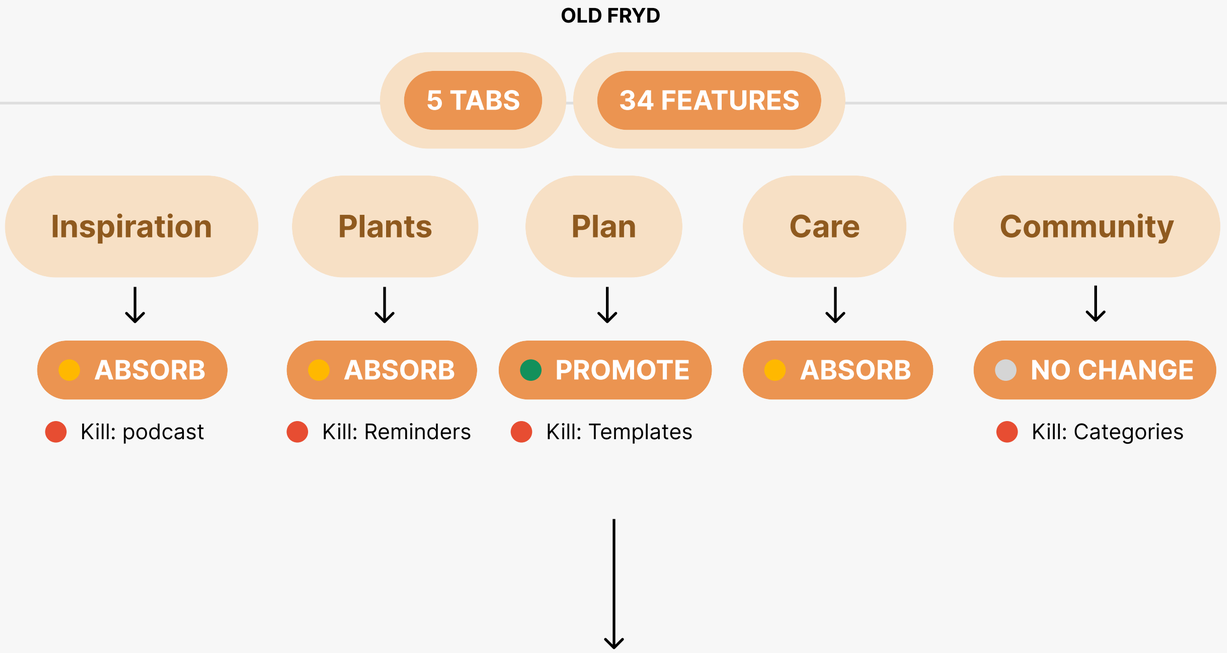
How to test such a hypothesis? What guarantees that AI input is trustworthy and valuable, and not generic slop? How to remove and absorb features without risking our users trust and losing our product value?



Approach

With a business shift towards revenue, the question became what users would actually pay for. Our tests pointed to guidance: the digest and journal had lifted trial starts. So we asked how to put guidance at the centre of the app and remove everything that diluted it.

In a “Marie Kondo” session, we ran a GA4 analysis with Claude, mapping and matching features against real usage, and we sorted them: absorb, kill or promote. Claude surfaced the usage patterns, and we decided what went away. We landed on a light version of the app, action-focused and a better hierarchy.



Simple Fryd

Solution

A simplified app and a companion living with our users, available at any time, with all the knowledge to stop second guessing every decision, whenever they need an extra layer of validation. Here comes, Aubergenius.

Ask Aubergenius

4 TABS

12 FEATURES

HOME

- AI Season Briefing
- AI Bed Overview
- AI Sow now
- Community Trending
- Magazine

GARDEN

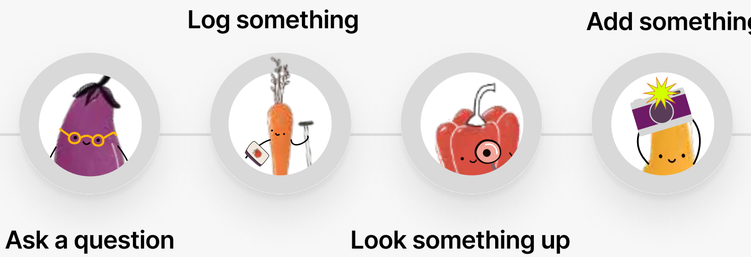
- Planner
- Memories
- Garden Activity

COMMUNITY

- Topic feed
- Posts, DMs, Profile

LAB

- Experiments
- Feedback



4 core actions

With this new skeleton, I identified 4 clear core actions to articulate the design around.

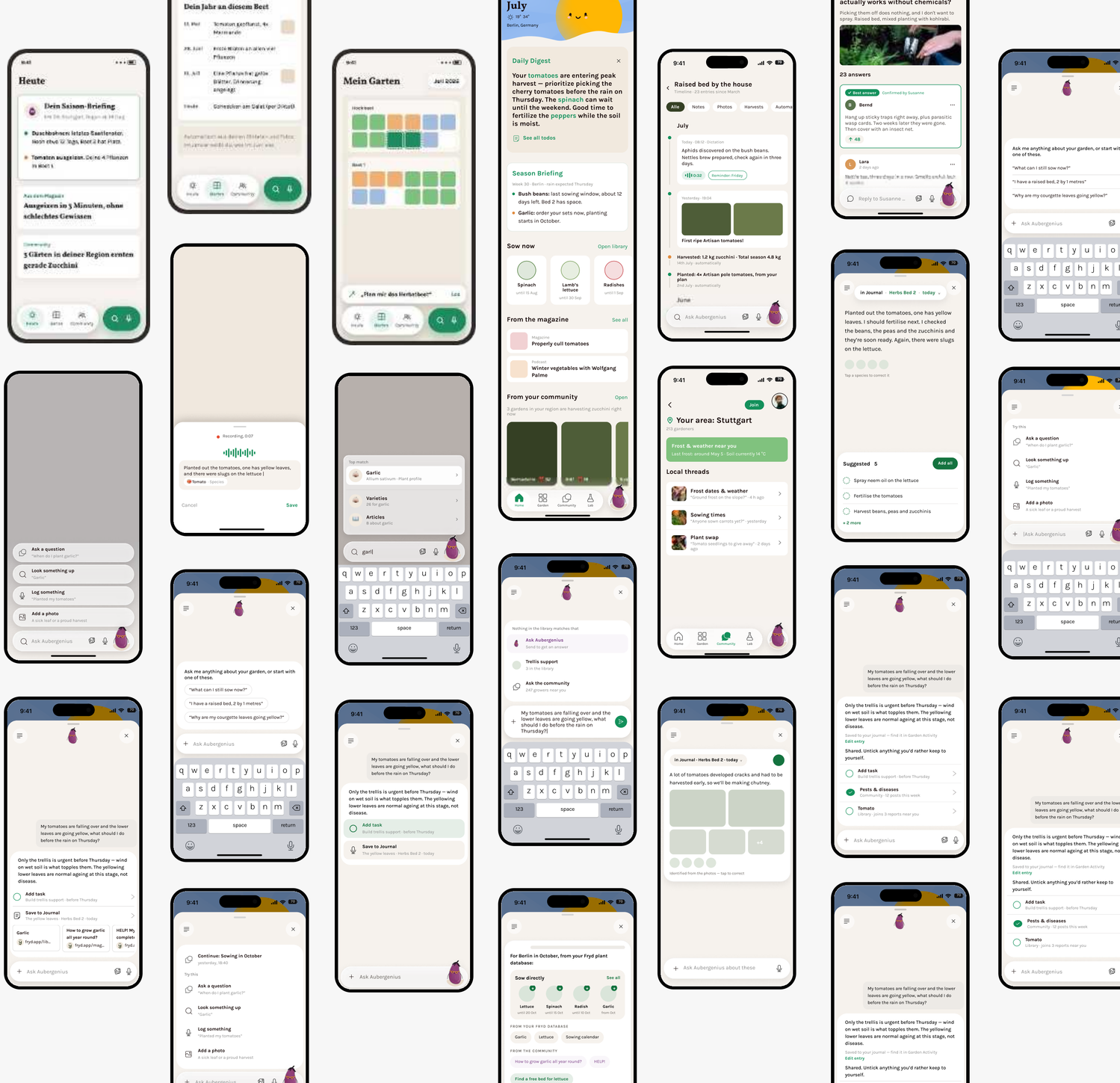
No generic AI content

The dev team engineered a closed MCP able to crawl the plant library, pests and diseases and Fryd's own community posts of all time, to have 100% control over the content generated. We kept the conversational style of Aubergenius to a minimum: it is action oriented, and suggests actions next steps but doesn't generate tons of contradictory generic content to not lower the trust level. This way, we were able to have more control on the amount of tokens used.

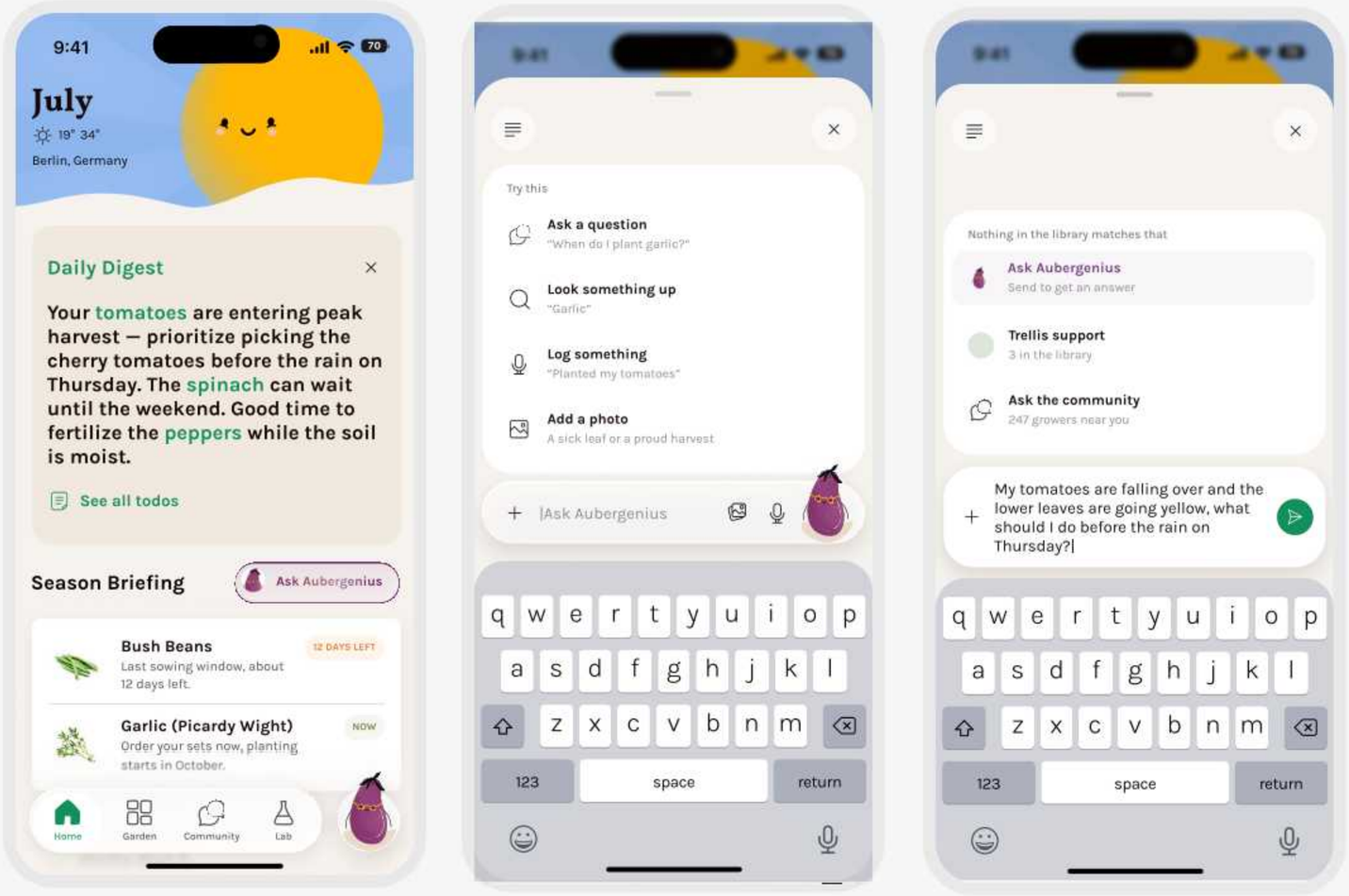
Mockups

Mockups were drafted by Claude Design for efficiency and variation during our exploration and discovery stage.

A full design by Claude at this point was not considered, as Claude consistently kept ignoring part of our design system, creating invalid components and changing tokens from our design system.



Ask something & Search: Exploration



Version 1

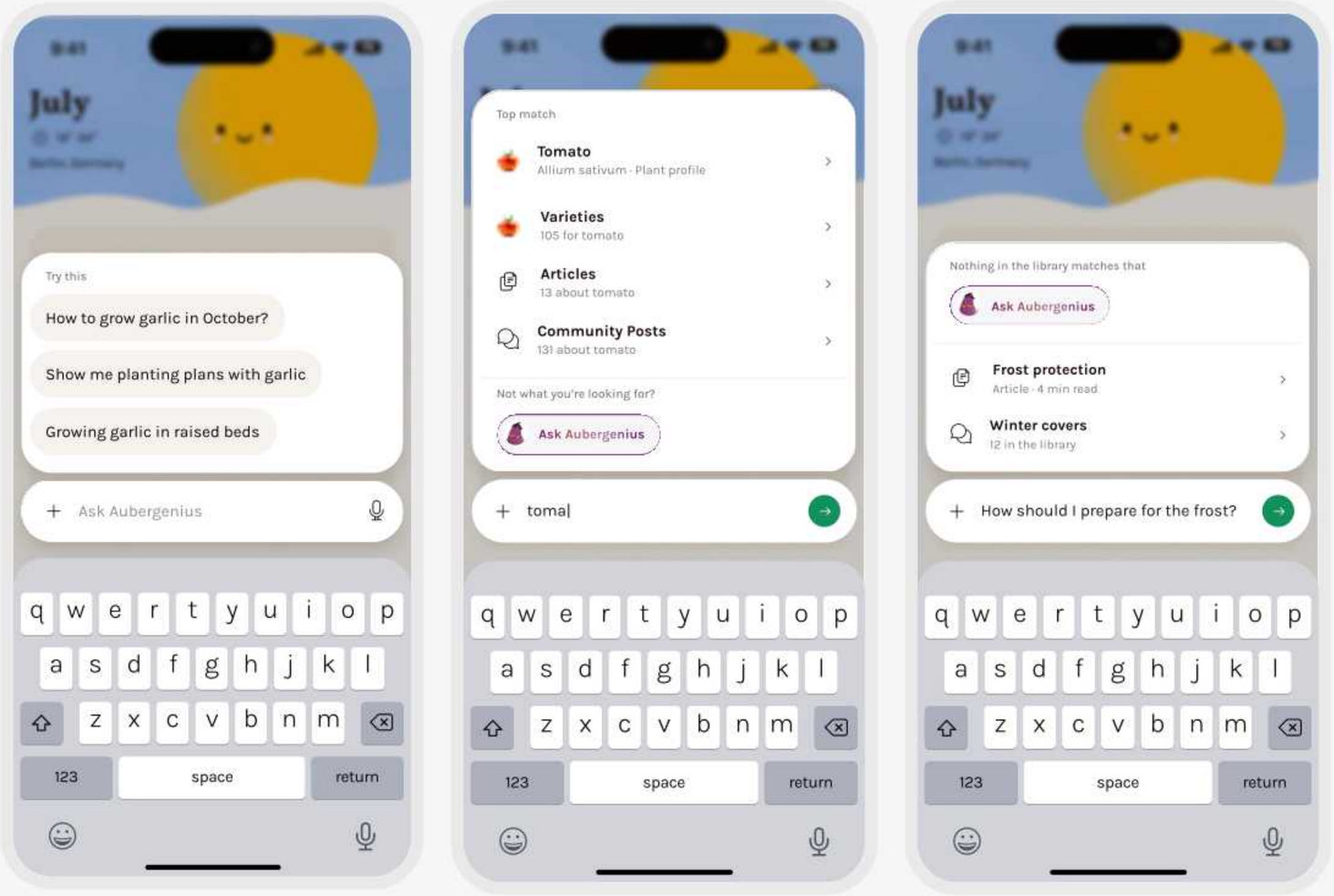
Conversation is the default mode. When interacting with Aubergenius, users are already in the conversation drawer and suggested to do one of the core actions.

Feedback

Drawer is quite intrusive and design feels like forcing a conversation instead of guiding. Search feels absorbed, it feels too much like talking to an AI.

Design decision

Drawer comes later → chatting with Aubergenius still needs to feel intentional and shouldn't fully replace smart search.



Version 2.2

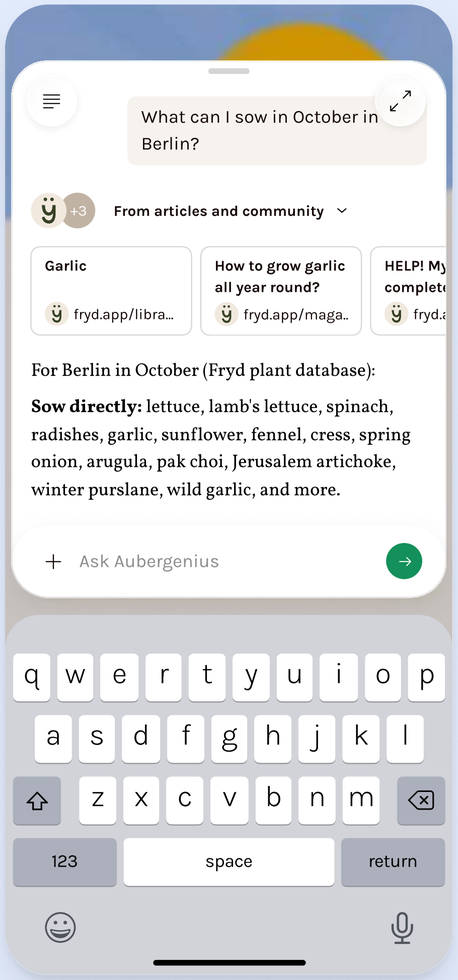
AI conversation is integrated within the search results. When nothing matches a search, user is prompted to ask Aubergenius.

Actions are no longer suggested, instead we suggest prompts. Conversation is still the primary focus, however a keyword search will still lead to a library results.

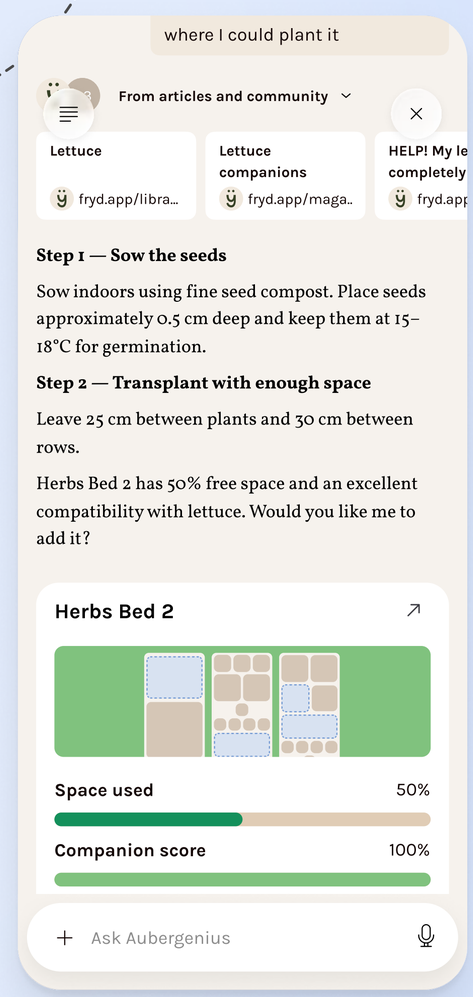
Actions are no longer suggested, instead we suggest prompts. Conversation is still the primary focus, however a keyword search will still lead to a library results.

From a quick question to the next step

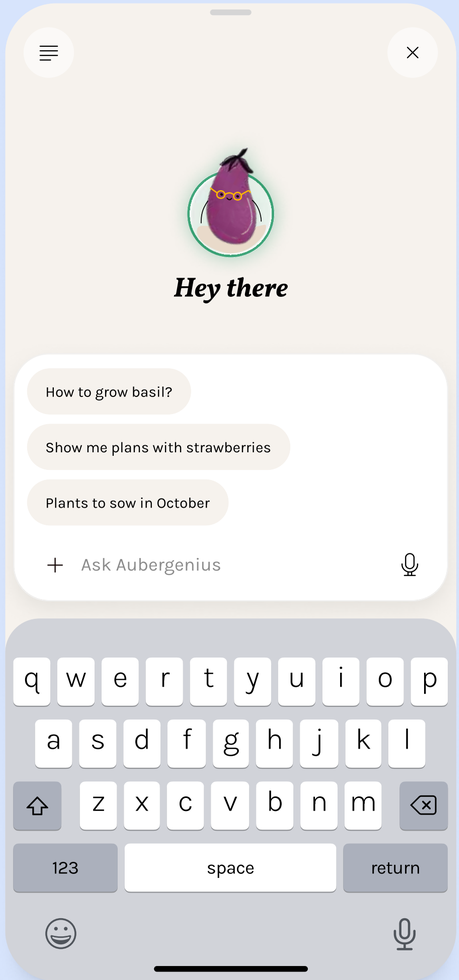
Quick search with Aubergenius



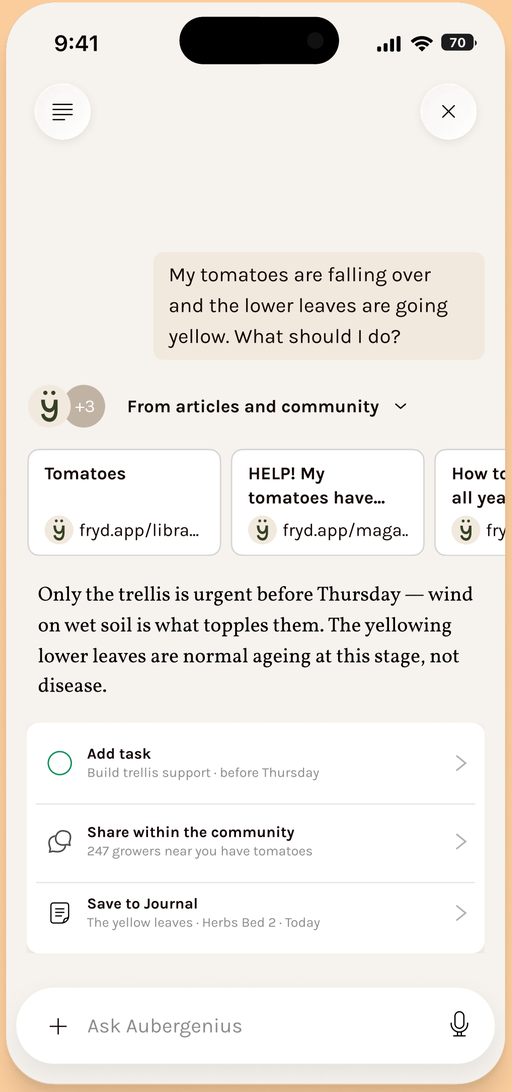
A reply to a quick search triggers a full screen interface

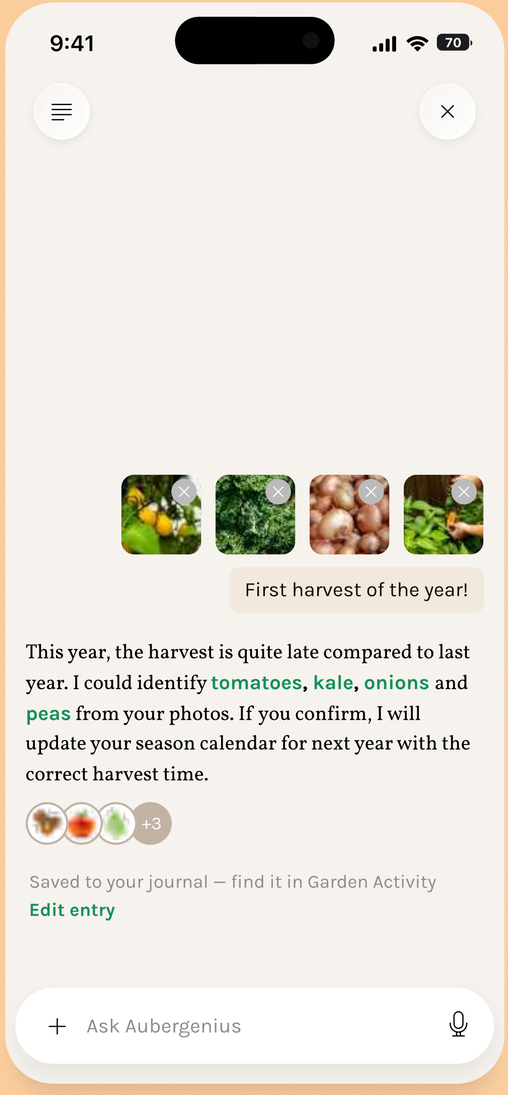


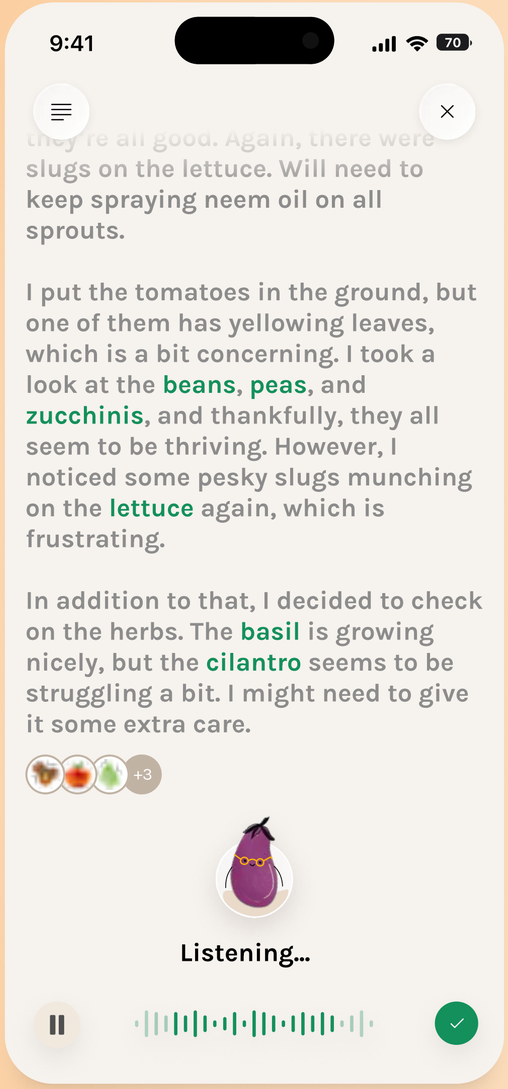
Cold start

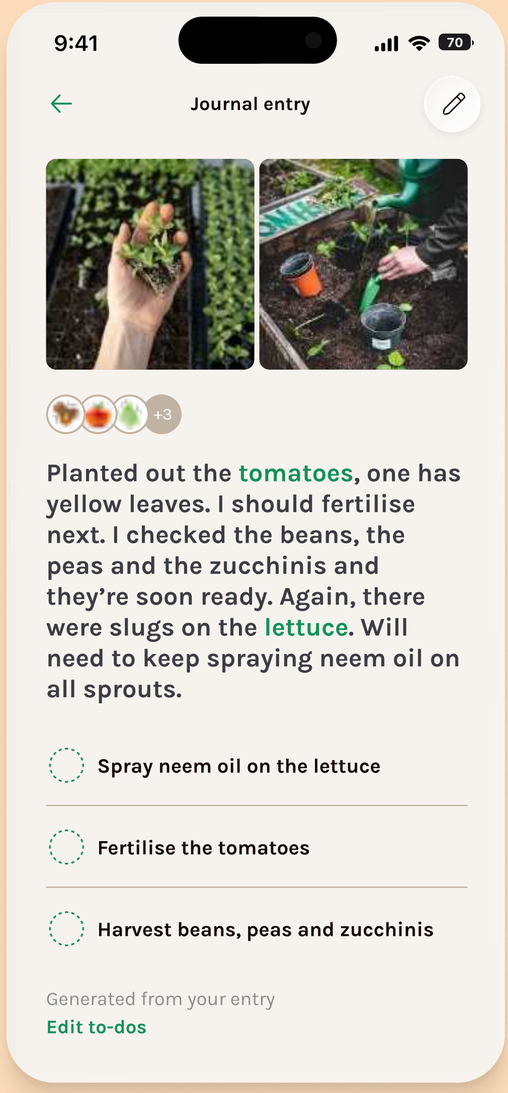


Aubergenius suggests and automates

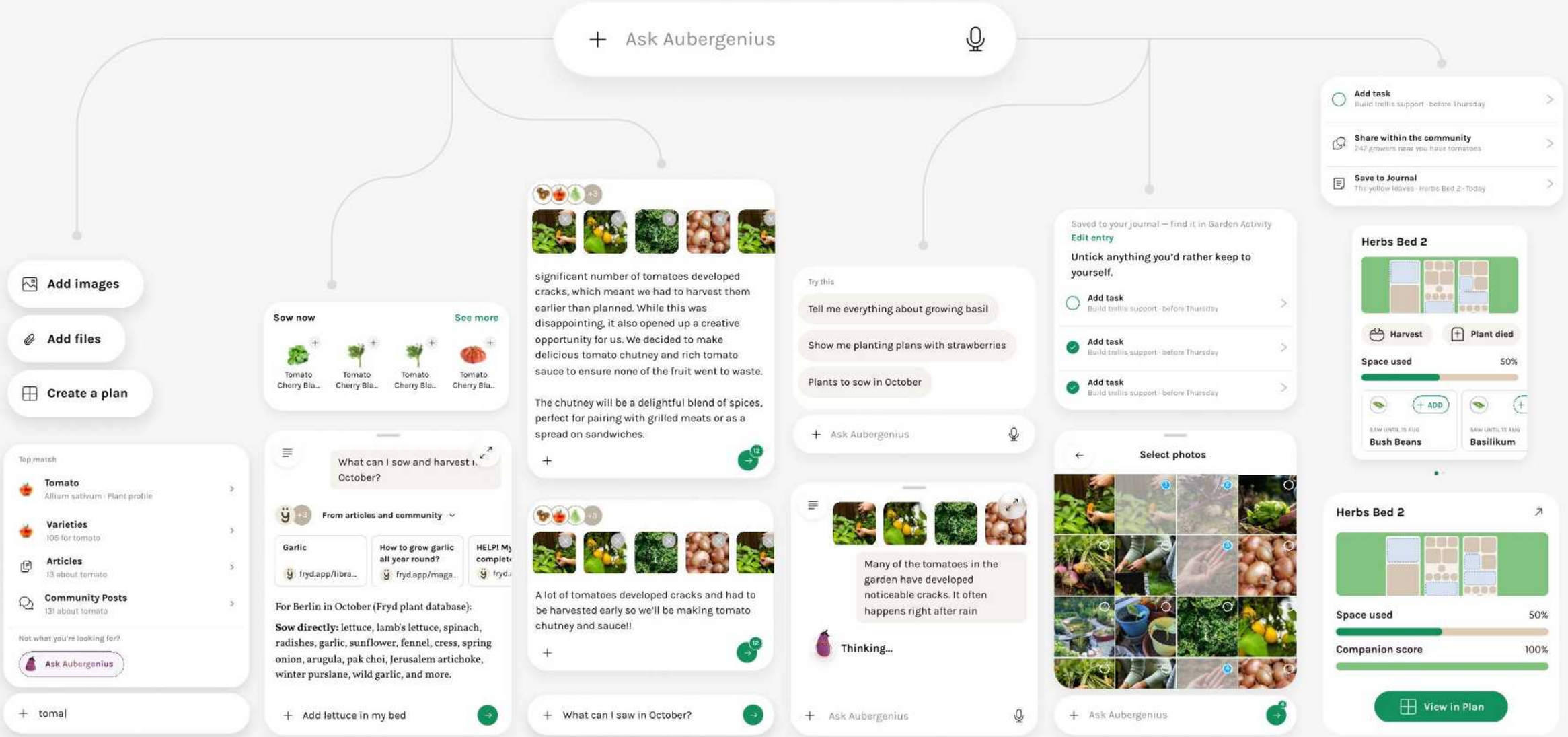








A floating modular system, around a single element

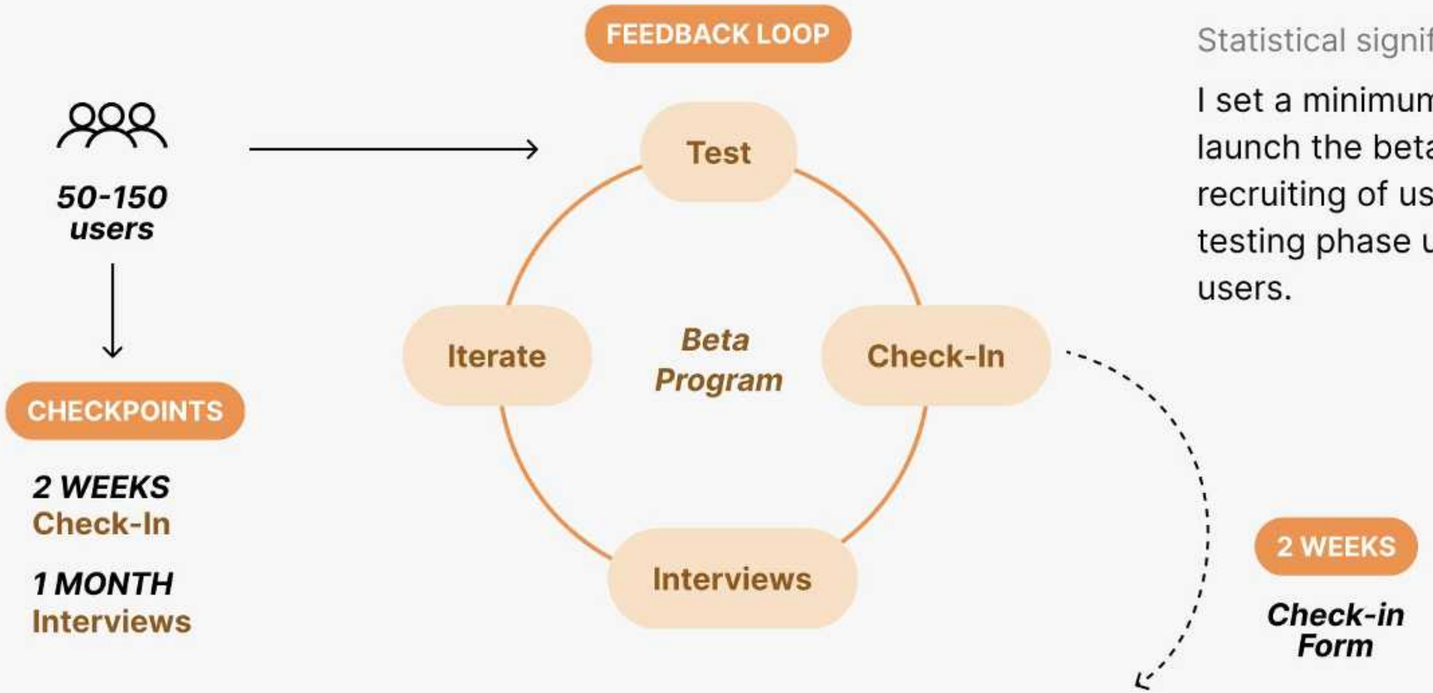


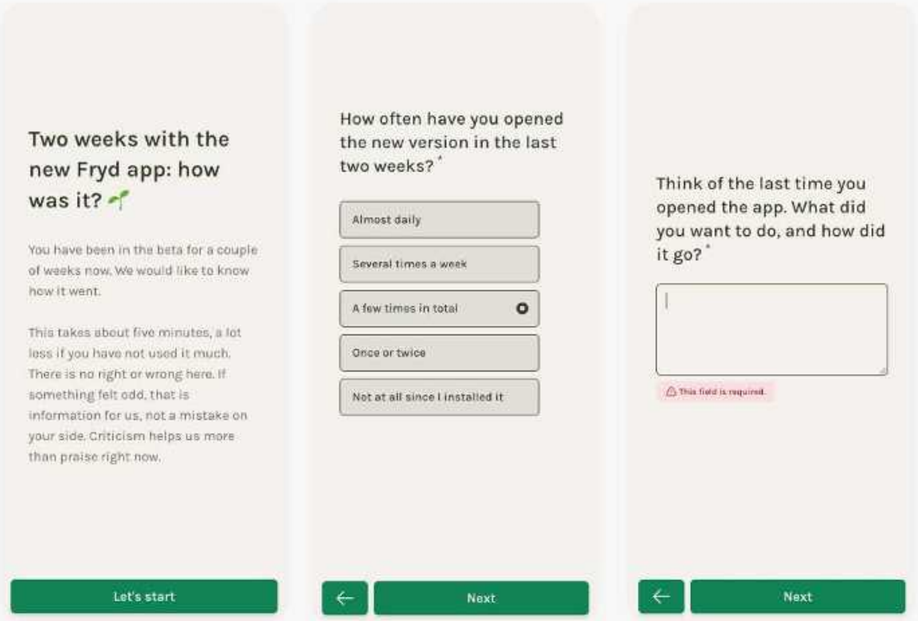
Testing

A conversational product depends on live answers, which a clickable prototype can't reproduce. So after designing in Figma, we went straight to a build and gave beta users the actual app through TestFlight. That meant testing real behaviour from day one, at the cost of heavier iteration through development.

Recruiting

Users were recruited through email and in-app forms (all user base, independent of their gardening level). We also handpicked experienced gardeners, who tend to be a sceptical and more tech-averted crowd.





Statistical significance

I set a minimum of 50 users to launch the beta, with a continuous recruiting of users during the first testing phase until reaching 150 users.

Success means users stop thinking of the app as a place to manage gardening tasks and start thinking of it as the first place they turn when they're unsure what to do next.

The beta began as I left the company in Aug 2026. I can’t speak of the results, but I can show I defined success and how the project was meant to be analysed.

		SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE	FAILURE LOOKS LIKE
HYPOTHESIS	Users understand they can "ask the app"	Most users use AI within their first session	They hunt through menus looking for features
	AI replaces navigation (library, articles)	Users complete tasks via chat with little friction	Users repeatedly abandon conversations and search manually
	Reddit-style community is easier to engage with	Higher number of posts, comments, and topic subscriptions	Users expect an endless feed and don't participate (empty town feeling)
	Hidden functionality doesn't reduce usability	Users discover advanced features naturally	Users believe functionality is missing

